

Leicester Church Congress 1919

Gerald T. Rimmington

The Church Congress held in Leicester during October 1919 was the fifty-fourth of its kind. Though it could be claimed that it was just following a well-established tradition, started in Cambridge during November 1861, it was nevertheless in some respects different from its predecessors. It used the same format of public meetings (like those of the British Association which the organisers used as a model), in which clergy and lay people listened to learned papers presented by experts, yet it came after a wartime gap of six years, the one planned for 1914 having been abandoned. It was, therefore, held at a time of deep reflection, the relief felt by the cessation of hostilities being tempered by worries about the future. Theodore Woods, the Bishop of Peterborough (within whose diocese Leicester lay), who presided over the Congress, hoped that 'the last shot had been fired [and] henceforth there would be among them fellowship, justice and peace', yet at the same time regretted that the Church lacked the means 'to save the Nation's soul from the material influences of industrial and commercial reconstruction'. (1) The mood in Leicester was summed up by the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society, whose *Report* in 1919 noted that its own organisation was 'passing through a critical time in which anxieties and hopes are blended'. (2)

Whereas in 1880, when Leicester had first hosted the Congress, the Bishop, William Connor Magee, was not initially enthusiastic about staging it because it cost him a trans-Atlantic trip, Theodore Woods was the prime mover in securing Leicester as the venue in 1919. (3) The editor of the *Official Report* noted that 'the Church Folk of Leicester, under the inspiring leadership of the Bishop of the Diocese, invited the Church Congress to meet in their city'. (4) One suspects that for both Bishop and people it was an opportunity to show Leicester to the country in its new guise as a 'city' rather than a very substantial town.

Leicester was a much better conference centre in 1919 than it had been in 1880. In the earlier year there had been no substantial hall in which meetings could be held. It had been necessary for the young Vicar of nearby St Peter's, Francis Robinson, to arrange for the erection of a temporary wooden building in Campbell Street, at a cost of £4,000, able to seat 4,000 people. (5) By 1919 however, the population had doubled, and the city's prosperity had enabled the Borough Council to build De Montfort Hall, opened in 1913. (6)

Despite the best intentions of Woods and his colleagues, and

their hard work in planning for the event, the Congress almost failed to convene. It was noted that 'within about a fortnight of the time fixed for the opening.... came the most serious Railway Strike ever known, and to many it seemed that the holding of the Church Congress.... was almost an impossibility'. However, the strike was settled on October 5th, a few days before the opening. (7) It must have resulted in a last minute surge of people declaring their intention to attend, for the Committee was forced to plead, in a newspaper advertisement as late as October 8th, 'for offers of hospitality' for an event scheduled to begin on October 13th. (8)

Before the beginning of the Congress there were preliminary rallies for boys, girls and men. It was noted that 'the number of lads present at the De Montfort Hall meeting yesterday [October 12th] approximated 3,000. The body of the hall was mainly occupied by local troops of Boy Scouts and the C[hurch] L[ads] B[rigade]'. The Archbishop of Canterbury, Randall Davidson, who was to preach the sermon at the opening service in St Martin's Church (soon to become the Cathedral) and remained throughout the whole of the proceedings, addressed the men's meeting, apparently to good effect. (9)

The editor of the *Leicester Mercury*, ever mindful that the Congress was coming to a city that had been known as the 'Capital of Nonconformity' because support for Dissent during the nineteenth century had been stronger than that for the Established Church, expressed concern on the first official day for co-operation between the Churches. This was followed up on the next day with 'hope that the Church Congress will bring about and consolidate that [Nonconformist] goodwill'. (10) There was in fact representation of Nonconformity in all of the sessions. Addresses of welcome were given by the Reverend Edward Elliott, Secretary of the Leicester Free Church Council, and G. Cresswell Turner, President of the Leicestershire and Rutland Free Church Federation and Vice-President of the Free Church Council. (11) Bishop Woods noted that 'throughout the country Churchmen and Nonconformists are increasingly co-operating in matters of social welfare the old weeds of envy, hatred, malice, and all uncharitableness have been rooted out, and a growing sense of fellowship in the things that matter have taken their place'. (12)

The theme of the Congress was 'The Church in a New Age'. The stated purpose was 'to demonstrate the special

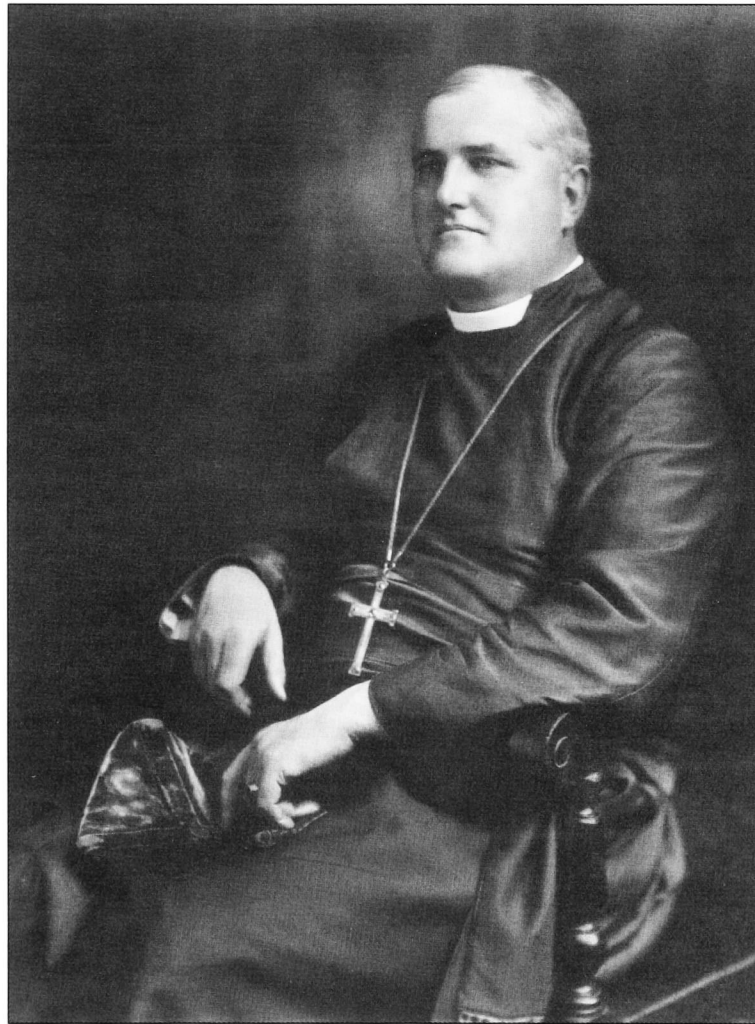
contribution the Church can make towards the reconstruction of national and international relationships in the New Age'. (13) The Executive Committee, chaired by Bishop Woods, had as its Vice-Chairman the Suffragan Bishop of Leicester (Norman McLeod Lang), and included in its membership the Mayor of Leicester (Alderman W. J. Lovell), the Reverend W. Elliott Thompson as Secretary, as well as five other clergymen and seven lay people (including one woman, Mrs C. F. Oliver), were clearly concerned about the role of the Church in the life of the nation as it faced the post-war years. This was outlined in the sub-themes: 'The Faith in the Light of the War', 'Christian Ideals in World Politics', 'The Christian Doctrine of the Future Life', 'Christian Ideals of Education' and 'Christian Ideals of Citizenship and Service'. The final sub-theme was divided into concerns about people in sexual relationships and those who led the single life, a recognition of the enormous loss of young men during the war, which denied marriage and children to many young women. (14)

There were, however, other concerns than recovery from war. For many years there had been an awareness that Leicester had been a city before. Between 690 and 874 it had been the centre of a see for the Bishop of the Middle Angles. (15) In 1919 though Leicester had resumed city status before the restoration of the diocese, a fact that no local politician could resist making reference to. Accordingly, at the opening ceremony, held in the Council Chamber, Alderman Lovell quipped that 'now the city has preceded the Bishop, and we hope before long the Bishop will be forthcoming'. (16)

The campaign for a bishopric was in fact nearing its conclusion. During the 1880s, when Bishop Magee was growing old and ailing, and had become rather tired of trying to cope with a diocese in which there were two diocesan conferences, one in Peterborough, the other in Leicester, so that 'everything had to be done in duplicate', it was accepted that sooner or later there would be a division into two dioceses. The appointment of Francis Thicknesse,

the Archdeacon of Northampton, as Suffragan Bishop of Leicester in 1888, was regarded as a step in that direction.

During the episcopate of Edward Carr Glyn further progress was made; although the Bishop himself was not entirely convinced of the wisdom of the separation he accepted that a smaller diocese would be easier to administer. But for the intervention of World War I Leicester would already have become the venue for a restored diocese. (17) This question overshadowed the whole of the proceedings of the Congress.



Frank Theodore Woods, Bishop of Peterborough, 1916-1923. (Reproduced by permission of the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester, and Rutland, location mark DE1564/854).

There was another concern, which had obtruded itself in the weeks before the Congress, the question of industrial relations. The recent 'most serious Railway Strike ever known' brought this sharply into focus. It would have been surprising if there had been no mention of it, even if it had not been planned originally. With this in mind the *Leicester Journal* considered that the leadership of the Leicester Congress was appropriate. Fortunately there was a presiding bishop who had been Vicar and Rural Dean in the great industrial city of Bradford and a Secretary in W. Elliott Thompson who had worked with Woods in Bradford. (18)

Bishop Woods did not disappoint, for in his inaugural address he referred to the Church's inaction during the Industrial Revolution: 'Instead of one great industrial comradeship of Britons, the workers.... assembled in two opposing camps, one labelled Capital and the other Labour. And the driving force of the whole, instead of being a sense of fellowship in the common welfare, was found in a bitter and soulless competition. He declared that the Church had been 'wholly preoccupied with the redemption of the individual as contrasted with the community'. He had no precise answers to the problems, but at least it stirred up debate in a subject that might not have been aired if the railway strike had not occurred. (19)

There were many other subjects covered during the Congress. Among them was Professor A. C. Headlam's lecture on ministerial conditions of work. He complained

that 'some 3275 livings [were] under the value of £200 a year, and 8029 under the value of £300, and [therefore] reform was necessary'. He noted that the head teachers of many first-grade public elementary schools earned more than £300 per annum. Accordingly he proposed an 'amalgamation of small livings; and a strong statutory Diocesan Finance Committee, with the power of dealing with all the Church endowments within the Diocese', together with 'a survey of the incomes and duties of the Deans and Chapters [of the Cathedrals]' and 'proper endowments of faculties of theology in the different Universities'. (20) Among the more spiritual addresses was one by Dean W. R. Inge on the 'Christian Doctrine of the Future Life', in which he declared that 'belief in perpetual progress as a law of nature was a superstition'. (21) Perhaps he exaggerated, but it was a truth that anyone who had lived through the Victorian and Edwardian eras followed by the recent war could accept.

In summing up the Congress Bishop Woods believed that there were three lessons to be learnt from the proceedings. Firstly, there was value in looking at differences between the Churches in a new spirit. He emphasised that no-one had a monopoly of the truth. Whereas at the 1880 Congress there had been concern at differences *within* the Church of England, there was no mention of this in 1919. Secondly, he was concerned about the immensity of the task the Church was facing. Thirdly, he felt that there was a 'new sense of the immeasurable resources of God available to the Churches' (22)

For those who were involved in the Church Congress of 1919 it must have seemed as if there was a new dawn in the affairs of the Church and the society of which it was part. When the Congress had started in 1861 they were the only place where clergy and laity met on equal terms. They were the main vehicles for promoting understanding between the Churches. There was even some hope that Congress might become a national synod for the Anglican Church, which had had no other truly representative body. Hopes were high. (23)

In the meantime, however, there had been some changes in church governance which ruled out this possibility. In 1885 a house of laity had been added to the Convocation of Canterbury. York had followed suit in 1892. By 1919 the Enabling Act was providing for the creation of a National Assembly that would bring both of these bodies together. (24) In the same piece of legislation there was also provision for statutory parochial church councils to work with incumbents. (25) Moreover, Arthur Burns has shown how Diocesan Assemblies had developed during the 1860s. (26) There were, therefore, responsible elective bodies at various levels in the Church of England; this ensured that the Church

Congresses, interesting and meaningful as their proceedings might be, were not destined to fulfill a representative role.

References:

1. F. P. Armitage, *Leicester 1914-1918* (Leicester, 1933), 294, 302.
2. F. B. Lott, *The Centenary Book of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society* (Leicester, 1935), 188.
3. G. T. Rimmington, 'Leicester Church Congress 1880', *Leicestershire Historian*, 34 (1998), 8.
4. *The Official Report of the Church Congress held in Leicester, October, 1919* (hereafter referred to as Official Report), v.
5. Rimmington, 'Leicester Church Congress 1880', 8; Also *Leicester Journal*, 17th October, 1919.
6. *Leicester Mercury*, 13th October, 1919.
7. *Official Report*, v.
8. *Leicester Mercury*, 8th October, 1919.
9. *Official Report*, vi
10. *Leicester Mercury*, 13th October, 1919.
11. *Official Report*, vi.
12. *Ibid.*, 5.
13. *Ibid.*, vi.
14. *Ibid.*, ix.
15. G. T. Rimmington, *Bishop Cyril Bardsley and the Diocese of Leicester 1927-1940* (Leicester Cathedral Publication, 1999), 2-3.
16. *Official Report*, ix.
17. John Beckett, 'Leicester becomes a city, 1919', *Transactions of the Leicestershire Archaeological and Historical Society*, 80 (2006), 152.
18. *Leicester Journal*, 17th October, 1919.
19. *Official Report*, 34.
20. *Leicester Journal*, 24th October, 1919; also *Leicester Mercury*, 16th October, 1919.
21. *Leicester Mercury*, 15th October, 1919.
22. *Ibid.*, 17th October, 1919.
23. Owen Chadwick, *The Victorian Church, II* (1860-1901) (2nd Edition, 1972), 364.
24. *Ibid.*, 365. The National Assembly was known as the Representative Church Council with 'the special powers of presenting measures for royal assent provided that they were reported on favourably by an ecclesiastical committee of both houses and a motion that they should be so presented was carried in both houses of Parliament'.
25. G. T. Rimmington, 'Clerical Incumbents in Leicestershire between the Two World Wars', *Transactions of the Leicestershire Archaeological and Historical Society*, 80 (2006), 164.
26. A. Burns, *The Diocesan Revival in the Church of England c. 1800-1870* (Oxford, 1999), 250ff, see also G. T. Rimmington, 'Bishop W. C. Magee and the Town of Leicester 1868-1891', *Midland History*, XXIII (1998), 131-132.